for civil servants to hold or express independent views of their own. They usually become part of the system.

Last but not the least, perhaps the most significant shortcoming of Raman's reports and notes on Khalistan/Sikh extremist affairs was that he was both the operational and analysis head of the newly created division to cover Sikh extremism or Khalistan-related activities in India and abroad, specially the latter. On the one hand he was producing and collecting raw and unprocessed intelligence, and on the other, as recipient of that same information, he was analysing and assessing its value for dissemination to important consumers. This is against the very basic tenets of intelligence. An operational officer is highly protective of information or intelligence produced by him or his juniors and views it in a subjective manner. Being so, he or she cannot be absolutely dispassionate and strictly objective in assessing its real worth. Under normal circumstances, the information has to pass the analytical test of accessibility, reliability and, finally, acceptability, under the vigilant eyes of an independent, knowledgeable and experienced analysis desk officer before it is processed and disseminated in a suitable manner to consumers.

On instructions from both Suntook and Gary Saxena, whenever Raman was out of station his assistant director would show me the drafts of reports meant for consumers outside the Department. I used to make changes in some of those drafts as they had a perceptible bias and showed a lack of proper understanding of the subject in its historical perspective. This process continued till early 1984, even though I had moved over to an analysis division in November 1983.

To be fair to Raman, he was not a careerist who would ingratiate himself with the powers-that-be by suitably tweaking his reports. In fact, he was just the opposite. As additional secretary, because of his outstanding service record, in the proceedings of the departmental promotion committee (DPC), he had superseded some officers who were a couple of years senior to him for promotion to the next rank. He should have been promoted to the rank of special secretary, but he preferred not to represent his case and finally retired as additional